

SPACE AND CULTURE

A Study on the Historical Evolution of Cemeteries and Tombstone Architecture in Modern Macao

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cemetery layouts
/
tombstone forms
/
religious symbols

Burial heritage is often treated as background, but it can be read as historical evidence.

Common reading
cemeteries as local history, isolated
sites, or funerary art

This paper's move
cemeteries as material sources for colonial
urban history and intercultural
communication

Research question
How did burial spaces and tombstone
forms register Macao's transition from
separate governance to plural
coexistence?

- Focus: spatial distribution, historical phases, religious plurality, and hybrid tombstone symbols.

Seventeen cemeteries become a cross-cultural archive when read together.



Macao Peninsula

6 cemeteries
colonial core
Western-style / religiously marked



Taipa

5 cemeteries
transition zone
municipal + community forms



Coloane

6 cemeteries
village society
Chinese-style / clan memory

Fieldwork + written records + tombstone architecture

The burial system moves from dispersal to public, regulated and intensive forms.



Cemetery geography mirrors Macao's colonial urban structure.

Peninsula

colonial governance core

- Western-style cemetery forms
- Catholic / Protestant / Islamic / Zoroastrian sites
- religious affiliation made visible in space

Outlying islands

Chinese village society

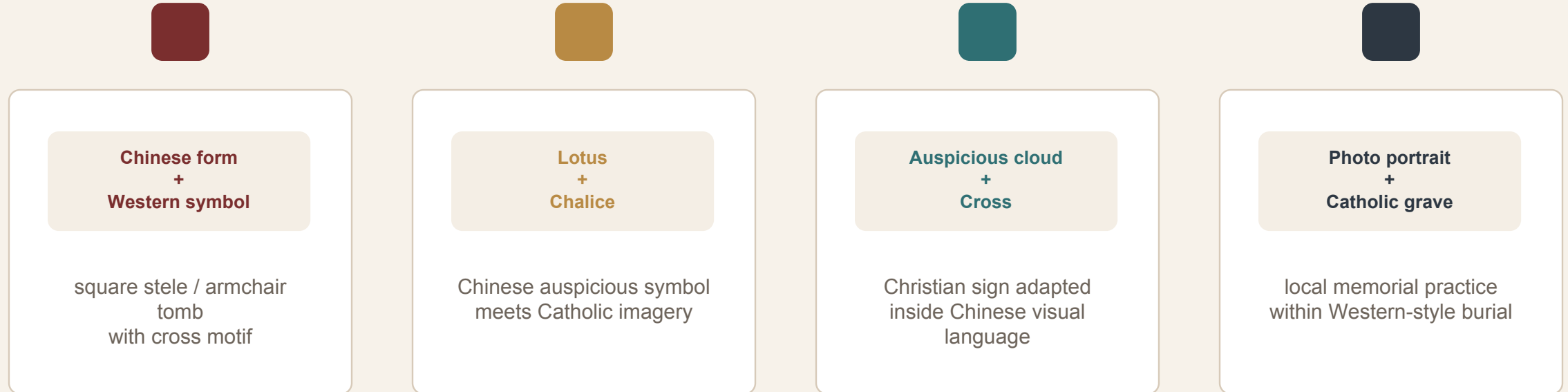
- Chinese armchair and pavilion tombs
- clan and community-based cemeteries
- feng shui, hillside layouts, local memory

Spatial divide: not fixed separation, but a historical starting point for later integration

Religious plurality is mapped through cemetery form, location and inscription.

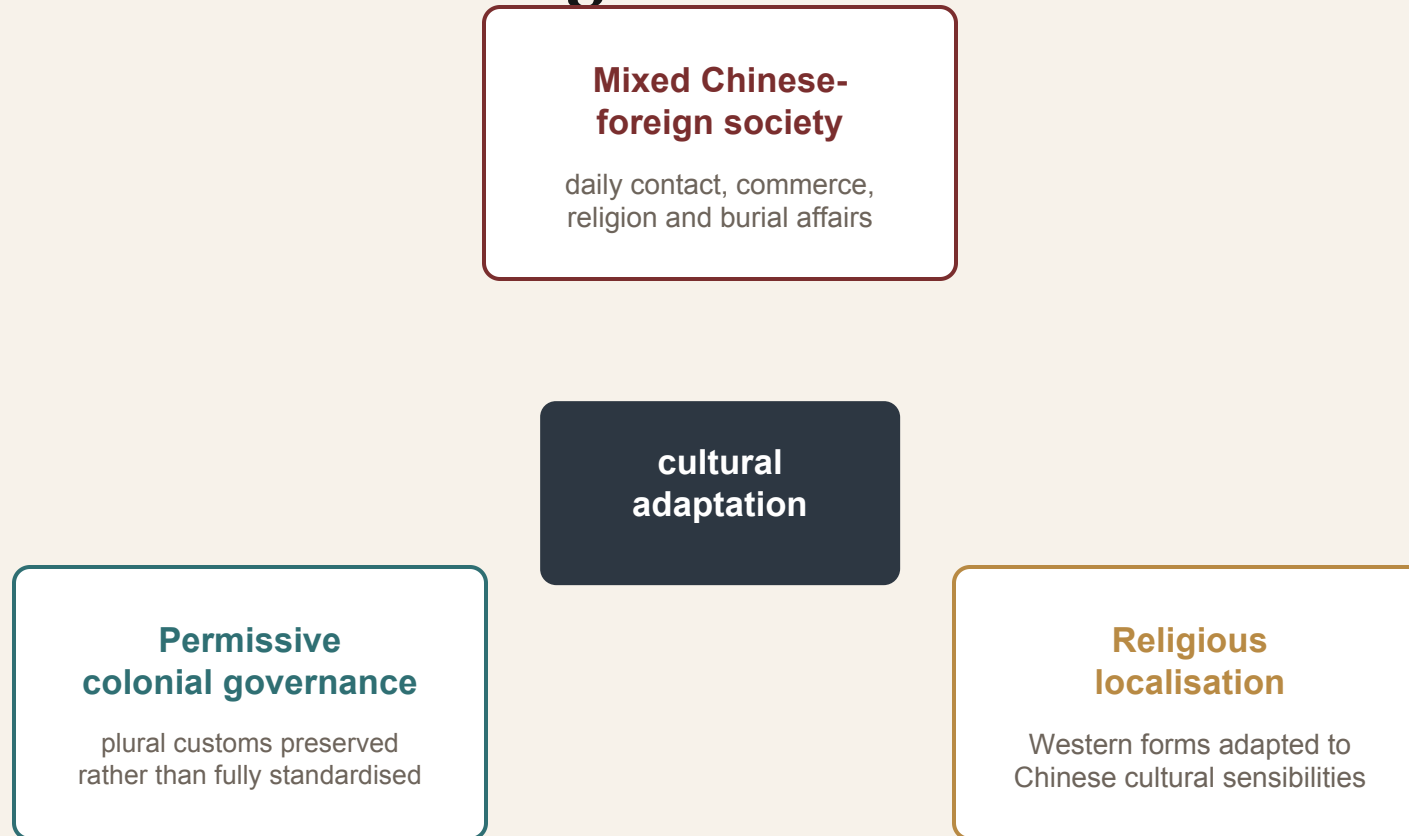
Tradition	Material markers	Historical reading
Catholic	crosses, angels, Marian figures	Latin / Portuguese; later Chinese
Protestant	plain headstones, biblical inscriptions	European and Chinese Protestants
Islamic	Arabic inscriptions, crescent motifs	merchant and labour migration traces
Zoroastrian	stone coffin forms, multilingual inscriptions	minority religious presence
Chinese traditions	armchair tombs, auspicious motifs, feng shui	clan memory and village order

Hybrid tombstones show localisation rather than simple cultural coexistence.



Integration happens at the scale of form, image and ritual practice

Integration was produced by social contact, permissive governance and religious localisation.



Burial choices reveal Macao's shift from receiving cultures to generating local identity.



- Hybrid tombstones can mark dual belonging: ethnic memory and religious commitment.

Heritage protection should preserve relationships, not only individual monuments.

01

Document

spatial layouts, inscriptions,
forms and symbolic motifs

02

Compare

Macao with Zhuhai,
Guangzhou and Quanzhou

03

Digitise

build structured records
for future conservation

A cemetery is not only a site; it is a network of space, object, ritual and memory

Macao's burial heritage reframes intercultural communication as material practice.

1

Historical

cemeteries trace Macao's movement from separate governance to plural coexistence

2

Spatial

peninsula and islands preserve different but connected cultural geographies

3

Material

hybrid tombstones make adaptation and identity-building visible

Thank you.